

Reduplication Meets Focus: The Scalar and Verum Readings of 'X mi X' Construction in Turkish

Ateş İsmail Çalışır

Georg-August University Göttingen RTG 2636: Form-Meaning Mismatches

22. ICTL

Roadmap

- Focus in Turkish, the Focus Sensitive Question Particle -mi
- Introducing X mi X Construction
- Syntactic Analysis
- Semantic/Pragmatic Analysis
- Open questions

Focus in Turkish

- The canonical focus position in Turkish is immediately preverbal

- Nuclear pitch accent falls on the focussed constituent

- (1) Volkan dün İstanbul-a git-ti
Volkan yesterday Istanbul-DAT go-PST Broad Focus, TP focus, object focus

“Volkan went to Istanbul yesterday.”

İşsever (2006)

- (2) Volkan İstanbul-a dün git-ti.
Volkan Istanbul-DAT yesterday go-PST

Narrow Focus

“Volkan went to Istanbul yesterday.”

İşsever (2006)

-mİ: Focus sensitive polar question marker

- -mİ is a focus sensitive polar question particle, is obligatory in questions

- (3) Volkan dün İstanbul-a=mİ git-ti?
Volkan yesterday Istanbul-DAT=Q go-PST
“Did Volkan go to Istanbul yesterday?”

İşsever (2006)

- It can attach to any constituent to create cleft-like focused polar questions

- (4) Volkan İstanbul-a dün=mü git-ti?
Volkan Istanbul-DAT yesterday=Q go-PST
“Was it yesterday when Volkan went to Istanbul?”

İşsever (2006)

- Can attach to any constituent, the constituent doesn't have to move to the preverbal position.
- In such cases, the nuclear pitch accent appears on the constituent -ml attaches to

- (5) Volkan dün=mü İstanbul-a git-ti?
 Volkan yesterday=Q Istanbul-DAT go-PST
 “Was it yesterday that Volkan went to Istanbul?”

- Post-verbal cases of -ml create polarity focus

- (6) Volkan dün İstanbul-a git-ti=mi? Kamali (2020)
 Volkan yesterday Istanbul-DAT go-PST=Q
 “Did Volkan go to Istanbul yesterday?”

-mİ and its syntactic properties

- Older theories posit -mİ as located in the C head and moving to the constituent with sentential focus post-syntactically
- This is not true: -mİ cannot intervene between specific elements, the position is not post-syntactic

- (7) A:* Ali araba=mİ için gel-di?
Ali car=Q for come-PST
Intended: “Did Ali come for the car?”

B: Ali araba için=mi gel-di?
Ali car for=Q come-PST
“Did Ali come for the car?”

- -mI's host takes scope > shows LF movement > can't be purely phonological

- (8) Bugün herkes gel-me-di.

today everyone come-NEG-PST

Available: "It's not the case that everybody came today." $\neg > \forall$

Unavailable: "It's the case that nobody came today." * $\forall > \neg$

- (9) Bugün herkes=mi gel-me-di?

today everyone=mI come-NEG-PST

Unavailable: "Is it not the case that everybody came today?" * $\neg > \forall$

Available: "Is it the case that nobody came today?" $\forall > \neg$

(Özyıldız, 2015, p. 6)

X=mI X Construction

- predicates can be put in “X mI X” configuration for emphasis

- (10) Güzel=mI güzel bir araba aldım.
 beautiful=mI beautiful a car bought.1sg
 “I bought a very beautiful car.”

- Verbal cases only has the “indeed” meaning (verum/polarity focus)

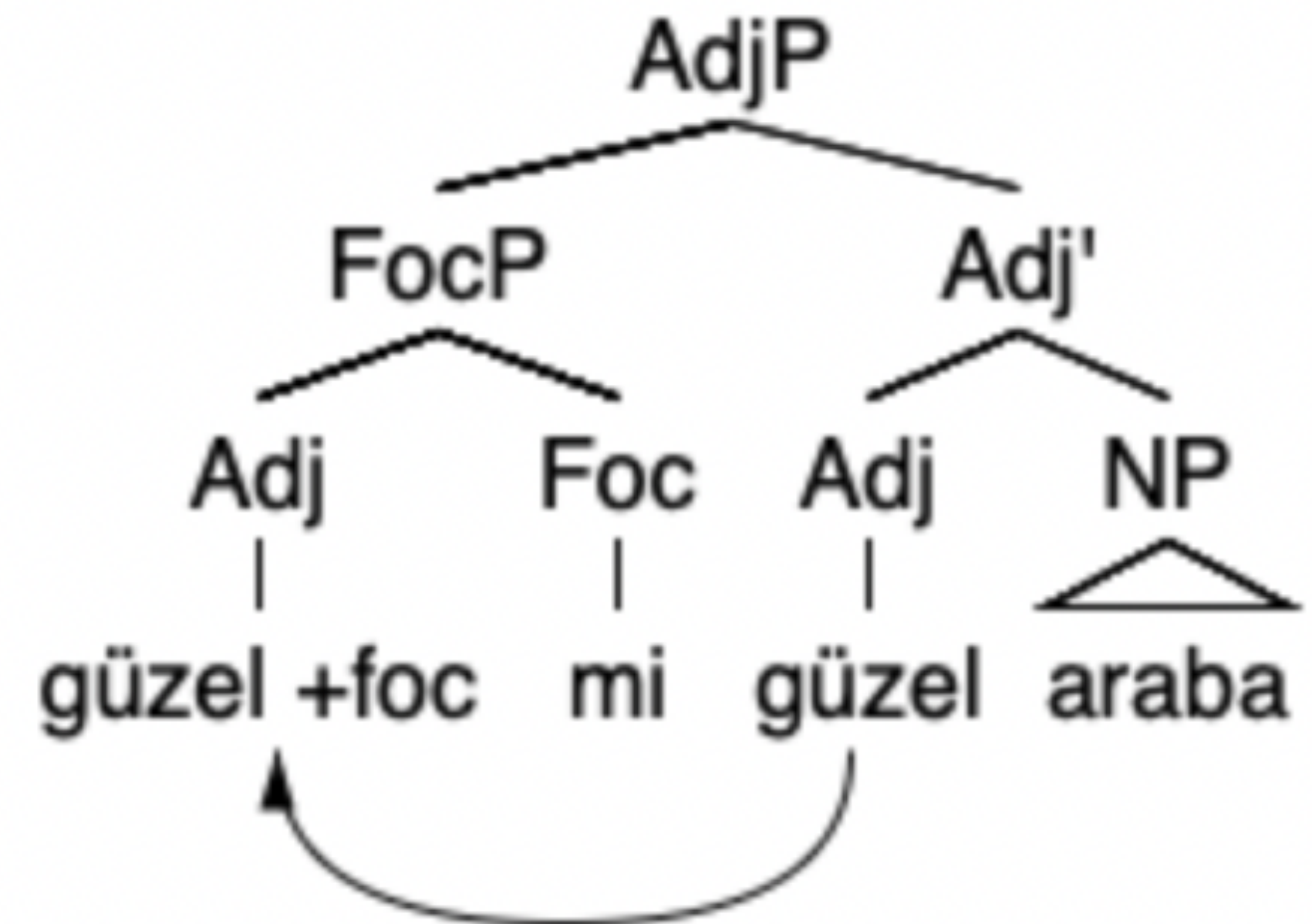
- (11) Yap-tım=mI yap-tım, ama mutlu ol-ma-dım
 do-PST.1sg=mI do-PST.1sg but happy be-NEG-PST.1sg
 “I did it indeed, but it didn’t make me happy.”
 Literally: “Did I do it? Yes. But it didn’t make me happy.”

Travis 2001: Syntax of Reduplication

- An easy solution is adopting Travis (2001) and assuming that -mi is the head of FocP, sitting at specifier of AdjP
- This allows us to account for (12) as well. The difference is the head of FocP is not pronounced

- (12) Ali gel-di=mi?
Ali come-PST=Q
“Did Ali come?”

Gel-di gel-di
come-PST come-PST
“He did come.”



Caponigro & Davidson (2011): Question-Answer Clauses (QACs)

- A similar phenomenon is also found in American Sign Language (ASL)
- The signer asks and gives the answer in the same string, akin to “the (true) answer to the question is..”
- They analyze the string as an embedded question and a declarative together. (fares better than Kimper’s theory wrt. word order)

- (13)
$$\begin{array}{c} \text{—————} \textit{br} \\ \text{[Q-constituent JOHN BUY WHAT], [A-constituent BOOK].} \\ \text{‘What John bought is a book.’} \end{array}$$

- (14)
$$\begin{array}{c} \text{—————} \textit{br} \\ \text{[Q-const MEG LAUGH], [A-const NO (MEG NOT LAUGH)]} \\ \text{‘Meg was not laughing.’} \end{array}$$

*br is brow raise, signals an interrogative

- The semantic analysis of QACs are relatively simple, they are copular constructions (copula is null) where the QAC establishes an identity between a question and its true answer.
- (15)
$$\begin{aligned} & [VP \ [CP \ w \ Ans_{STRONG} \ MEG \ LAUGH] \\ & \quad [V' \ e_{BE} \ [NO, (MEG \ NOT \ LAUGH)]]] \rightsquigarrow \\ & \lambda q[q = \lambda w_1 \neg \mathbf{laugh}(w_1)(m)] \ (ANS_{STRONG}(w_0)(Q_0)) \Rightarrow \\ & \quad ANS_{STRONG}(w_0)(Q_0) = \lambda w_1 \neg \mathbf{laugh}(w_1)(m) \end{aligned}$$
- The main contribution of this construction compared to a declarative sentence is the strong exhaustivity. This results in **focus**.
- Under the QUD theory, Caponigro & Davidson analyze the QACs as raising a QUD and resolving it in the same string. = focus

Hello, it's -mI again

- C&D's analysis can be applied to Turkish, X-mI brings about the alternatives, the second instance of X asserts the proposition and exhausts the alternatives.
- The copular requirement is also visible when X is a noun
- (16) Arabayı yıka-yan Ali=mi Ali
Car.ACC wash-NOMIN Ali=Q Ali
“It's indeed Ali who is washing the car.”
- (17) * Arabayı Ali=mi Ali yıka-dı
Car.ACC Ali=Q Ali wash-PST
Intended: “ALI washed the car.”

The Intensification Inference

- X-mI X with gradeable adjectives has “very” meaning.
- **(10)** Güzel=mi güzel bir araba aldım.
 beautiful=mI beautiful a car bought.1sg
 “I bought a very beautiful car.”
- Simple explanation: pragmatic competition, the speaker utters the more complex form, violating the maxim of manner > intensification. BUT this implicature is not cancellable:
- **(18) #** Güzel=mi güzel bir araba aldım, ama çok güzel değil.
 beautiful=Q beau a car bought.1sg but very beautiful not
 “I bought a BEAUTIFUL car, but its not a very beautiful car.”

Manner Implicature

- Katzir 2007: scalar implicatures resulting from structural alternatives
- These alternatives are generated by replacing the form with **equal** or **lesser** complexity
- They compete with simpler forms ('X' vs. 'X mi X')
- *Güzel mi güzel araba* competes with the simpler *güzel araba*, this results in manner implicature
- The speaker could have said the simpler form, by not uttering the simpler form, the speaker signals extra information

Epistemic Intensification

- Certain epistemic adverbs like *really* also carry the same non-cancellable intensification implicature:
- (19) # The car is really beautiful, but it's not very beautiful.
- “The contrastivity is a consequence of the fact that assertive propositions come with assumption of truth, and the explicit marking of truth by *really* tends to create a context where the opposite is presupposed. ” (Paradis, 2003)
- The invited inference when *really* takes scope over a scalar property of an adjective is that what is real and true with respect to a scalar property implies “boosting of this property”
- Based on cognitive semantics, no precise explanation of the mechanism.

Adverbs of Veracity (Masià 2019)

- Masià (2019) proposes that adverbs of veracity are vagueness regulators
- They reduce the denotation of the property to the best exemplars of the category by restricting the domain to entities that are already in the positive extension of P in the context.
- The new standard for the predicate is thus calculated based on the set of entities that were already in its denotation in the context. > very similar to *very*
- (20) $\llbracket \textit{very} \rrbracket^c = \lambda G \lambda x. \exists d [\mathbf{standard}(d)(G)(\lambda y. \llbracket \textit{pos}(G)(y) \rrbracket^c) \wedge G(d)(x)]$
- (21) $\llbracket \textit{true } P \rrbracket = \lambda x. \mathbf{deg}(x, P, c, g) \succeq \mathbf{Standard}(\textit{true}(P), c, g) =$
 $= \lambda x. \mathbf{deg}(x, P, c, g) \succeq \mathbf{S}(P, c, g, \llbracket P \rrbracket^+)$
- By virtue of uttering the answer to the question “X mi?”, the speaker says “X is true”

Open Questions

- There are other reduplication strategies that might be related to X-mı X
- (22) Güpgüzel bir araba aldım.
beau-beautiful a car bought.1sg
“I bought a very beautiful car.”
- The conditional link could be explained in a similar way, but not yet clear how
- (23) Ali geldi=mi gideriz.
Ali come.PST=Q go.1pl.AOR
“We will go once Ali comes.”

Thank you for listening!

References

- Caponigro, I., & Davidson, K. (2011). Ask, and tell as well: Question–Answer Clauses in American Sign Language. *Natural Language Semantics*, 19(4), 323–371.
- Ghomeshi, Jila, Ray Jackendoff, Nicole Rosen and Kevin Russell. 2000. Contrastive Focus Reduplication in English. Paper read at Canadian Linguistics Association, University of Alberta.
- Göksel, A., Kabak, B., & Revithiadou, A. (2013). Prosodically constrained non-local doubling. *The Linguistic Review*, 30(2).
- Höhle, Tilman. 1992. ‘Ueber Verum Fokus in Deutschen’, *Linguistische Berichte* Sonderheft 4, 112–141. İşsever, Selçuk. 2006. “On the NSR and Focus Projection in Turkish” In book: *Advances in Turkish Linguistics: proceedings of the 12th international conference on Turkish linguistics* Publisher: Dokuz Eylül University Press. Editors: S. Yağcıoğlu, A. Cem Değer
- İşsever, Selçuk. 2006. “On the NSR and Focus Projection in Turkish” In book: *Advances in Turkish Linguistics: proceedings of the 12th international conference on Turkish linguistics*
- Kamali, Beste. 2015. Information structure in Turkish yes/no questions. In U. Ataş et al. (eds.), *Ankara papers in Turkish and Turkic linguistics*, 27–39. Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz.
- Kamali, Beste. 2020. Motivating polar and focal alternatives in polar questions in broad focus. [lingbuzz/005477](#)
- Katzir, R. (2007). Structurally-defined alternatives. *Linguistics and Philosophy*, 30(6), 669–690.
- Kimper A Wendell. 2008. Syntactic Reduplication and the spellout of movement chains. Amherst: University of Massachusetts Amherst.
- Masià, M. S. (2019). Adjectives of veracity as vagueness regulators. *Proceedings of Sinn Und Bedeutung*, 19, 413–430.
- Özyıldız, Deniz. 2015. Move to to mi but only if you can. Ms. UMass Amherst
- Paradis, C. (2003). Between epistemic modality and degree: the case of really. In R. Facchinetti, M. Krug, & F. Palmer (Eds.), *Modality in Contemporary English* Mouton de Gruyter
- Rooth, Mats. (2016). *Alternative Semantics*. 10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199642670.013.19.
- Travis, Lisa. (2001). The syntax of reduplication. *Proceedings of NELS* 31. 455-469.